

## THE OTHER DEATH

A couple of years ago (I have lost the letter), Gannon wrote to me from Gualeguaychú announcing that he was sending me a translation—perhaps the first in Spanish—of Ralph Waldo Emerson's poem *The Past*, and adding in a postscript that Don Pedro Damián, whom I might remember, had died a few nights before of pulmonary congestion. The man, ravaged by fever, had relived in his delirium the bloody day at Masoller. The news struck me as predictable, even conventional, for Don Pedro, at nineteen or twenty, had followed the banners of Aparicio Saravia. The revolution of 1904 caught him working as a ranch hand in Río Negro or Paysandú. Pedro Damián was from Entre Ríos, from Gualeguay, but he went where his friends went, as spirited and as ignorant as they were. He fought in some skirmish and in the final battle; repatriated in 1905, he returned with humble tenacity to his rural labors. As far as I know, he never left his province again. The last thirty years he spent in a remote outpost a league or two from Ñancay. In that desolate place, I once tried to talk with him (around 1942). He was a taciturn man of little learning. The sound and fury of Masoller were his entire history; it did not surprise me that he relived them at the hour of his death... I knew I would never see Damián again and wanted to remember him; my visual memory is so poor that I could only recall a photograph Gannon had taken of him. This is hardly strange, considering I had seen the man only once, in early 1942, and his image many times. Gannon had sent me that photograph; I have lost it and no longer look for it. I would be afraid to find it.

The second episode took place in Montevideo months later. The fever and death throes of the man from Entre Ríos inspired me to write a fantastic tale about the defeat at Masoller. Emir Rodríguez Monegal, to whom I recounted the plot, gave me a note of introduction to Colonel Dionisio Tabares, who had fought in that campaign. The colonel received me after supper. From a rocking chair in a courtyard, he recalled those bygone days with disordered fondness. He spoke of ammunition that never arrived, of exhausted horses, of men covered in dust weaving labyrinths of marches, of Saravia, who could have taken Montevideo but veered away, "because the gaucho fears the city," of men slashed open to the neck, of a civil war that seemed to me less a clash of armies than the dream of a lone outlaw. He spoke of Illescas, of Tupambaé, of Masoller. His sentences were so polished and his delivery so vivid that I realized he had told these stories many times before, and I feared that behind his words there might be no real memories left. During a pause, I managed to slip in Damián's name.

"Damián? Pedro Damián?" the colonel said. "He served under me. The boys called him Daymán." He burst into loud laughter but cut it off abruptly, with either real or feigned discomfort.

In a different tone, he said that war, like women, served to test men, and that before going into battle, no one knew who he really was. Someone might think himself a coward and turn out brave, or the opposite, as happened to that poor Damián, who strutted around the taverns with his white insignia but faltered at Masoller. In some skirmish with the zumacos, he had fought like a man, but it was another story when the armies clashed, the cannons roared, and every man felt that five thousand others had joined forces to kill him. Poor kid—he had spent his life herding sheep, and suddenly he was swept up in that patriotic frenzy...

Absurdly, Tabares' version shamed me. I would have preferred things to have happened differently. Without meaning to, I had fashioned a kind of idol out of old Damián, whom I had glimpsed one afternoon many years before; Tabares' account shattered it. Suddenly I understood Damián's reserve and stubborn solitude: they had been dictated not by modesty but by humiliation. In vain I told myself that a man haunted by an act of cowardice is more complex and more interesting than a man who is merely brave. The gaucho Martín Fierro, I thought, is less memorable than Lord Jim or Razumov. True—but Damián, as a gaucho, was obliged to be Martín Fierro, especially among Uruguayan gauchos. In what Tabares said and left unsaid, I detected the raw flavor of what was called Artiguismo: the belief (perhaps indisputable) that Uruguay is more elemental than our country and therefore braver... I remember that that night we said goodbye with exaggerated warmth.

In the winter, lacking one or two details for my fantastic tale (which stubbornly refused to take shape), I went back to Colonel Tabares' house. I found him with another elderly gentleman: Dr. Juan Francisco Amaro, from Paysandú, who had also fought in Saravia's revolution. Predictably, the talk turned to Masoller. Amaro told a few stories and then added slowly, as if thinking aloud:

"We camped at Santa Irene, I remember, and some men joined us. Among them, a French veterinarian who died the day before the battle, and a young shearer from Entre Ríos, a certain Pedro Damián."

I interrupted him sharply.

"I know," I said. "The Argentine who faltered under fire." I stopped; both men were looking at me in bewilderment.

"You're mistaken, sir," Amaro said at last. "Pedro Damián died as any man would wish to die. It must have been four in the afternoon. The Red infantry had fortified the crest of the ridge; our men charged them with lances. Damián led the charge, shouting, and a bullet struck him square in the chest. He stood in the stirrups, finished his cry, and tumbled to the ground, where the horses trampled him. He was dead, and the final charge at Masoller swept over him. So brave, and he wasn't yet twenty."

He was clearly speaking of another Damián, but something made me ask what the boy had shouted.

"Curses," said the colonel, "which is what men shout in a charge."

"Maybe," said Amaro, "but he also shouted 'Long live Urquiza!'"

We fell silent. At last, the colonel murmured:

“Not as if he were fighting at Masoller, but at Cagancha or India Muerta, a century ago.” He added, genuinely perplexed:

“I commanded those troops, and I’d swear this is the first time I’ve heard of any Damián.”

We could not make him remember.

Back in Buenos Aires, my astonishment at his forgetfulness returned. One afternoon, in the basement of Mitchell’s English Bookshop, amid the eleven delightful volumes of Emerson’s works, I ran into Patricio Gannon. I asked him about his translation of *The Past*. He said he had no plans to translate it and that Spanish literature was so tedious it made Emerson unnecessary. I reminded him that he had promised me that version in the same letter in which he told me of Damián’s death. He asked who Damián was. I told him, to no avail. With a flicker of dread, I noticed his look of bewilderment and took refuge in a literary debate about Emerson’s detractors—a poet more complex, more skilled, and certainly more singular than the unfortunate Poe.

A few more facts must be recorded. In April, I received a letter from Colonel Dionisio Tabares; his confusion had lifted, and he now remembered very well the young man from Entre Ríos who had led the charge at Masoller and whose men buried him that night at the foot of the ridge. In July, I passed through Gualaguaychú but could not find Damián’s hut—no one remembered him anymore. I wanted to question Diego Abaroa, the ranch hand who had seen him die, but Abaroa had passed away before winter. I tried to recall Damián’s features; months later, flipping through some albums, I realized that the somber face I had managed to conjure was that of the famous tenor Tamberlick in the role of Othello.

Now I turn to conjecture. The easiest, though least satisfying, hypothesis is that there were two Damianes: the coward who died in Entre Ríos around 1946, and the brave one who died at Masoller in 1904. Its flaw is that it fails to explain what is truly enigmatic: the curious fluctuations in Colonel Tabares’ memory, the oblivion that in so short a time erased the image and even the name of the man who returned. (I reject—I refuse to accept—a simpler conjecture: that I dreamed the first one.) More intriguing is the supernatural hypothesis devised by Ulrike von Kühlmann. Pedro Damián, she said, perished in battle, and at the hour of his death, he begged God to send him back to Entre Ríos. God hesitated a second before granting this mercy, and by then the petitioner was already dead, and several men had seen him fall. God, who cannot alter the past but can alter its images, changed the image of death into that of a fainting spell, and the shade of the man from Entre Ríos returned to his homeland. He returned, but we must remember his condition as a shade. He lived in solitude, without a woman, without friends; he loved and possessed everything from afar, as if through glass. He “died,” and his faint image was lost, like water in water.

This conjecture is wrong, but it should have led me to the true one (which I now believe to be true), at once simpler and more extraordinary. I discovered it almost magically in Pier Damiani’s treatise *De Omnipotentia*, which I studied because of two lines from Canto XXI of the *Paradiso*

that pose precisely a problem of identity. In the fifth chapter of that treatise, Pier Damiani maintains—against Aristotle and Fredegarius of Tours—that God can undo what once was. Reading those old theological debates, I began to understand the tragic story of Don Pedro Damián.

I imagine it thus: Damián behaved like a coward on the field at Masoller and spent his life correcting that disgraceful weakness. He returned to Entre Ríos; he never raised his hand against another man, never sought a reputation for bravery, but in the fields of Ñancay, he toughened himself against the wilderness and the wild cattle. Unknowingly, he was preparing the miracle. He thought with all his soul: If fate brings me another battle, I will prove worthy of it. For forty years he waited in dark hope, and fate finally brought it to him at the hour of his death. It came as delirium, but the Greeks knew that we are the shadows of a dream. In his agony, he relived his battle and conducted himself like a man, leading the final charge, and a bullet struck him square in the chest. Thus, in 1946, through a long passion, Pedro Damián died in the defeat at Masoller, which took place between winter and spring of 1904.

The Summa Theologica denies that God can undo the past, but says nothing about the intricate concatenation of causes and effects—so vast and so intimate that perhaps not a single remote fact, however insignificant, could be annulled without invalidating the present. To modify the past is not to modify a single fact; it is to annul its consequences, which tend to be infinite. In other words, it is to create two universal histories. In the first (let us say), Pedro Damián died in Entre Ríos in 1946; in the second, at Masoller in 1904. This is the one we live now, but the suppression of the former was not immediate and produced the inconsistencies I have related. In Colonel Dionisio Tabares, the successive stages were fulfilled: first, he remembered Damián as a coward; then, he forgot him entirely; then, he recalled his valiant death. No less corroborative is the case of the ranch hand Abaroa, who died, I suspect, because he knew too much about Don Pedro Damián.

As for me, I do not think I run a similar danger. I have guessed and recorded a process inaccessible to men, a kind of scandal of reason; but certain circumstances mitigate that terrible privilege. For one, I am not sure of having always written the truth. I suspect that my story contains false memories. I suspect that Pedro Damián (if he existed) was not named Pedro Damián, and that I remember him by that name so that one day I may believe his story was suggested to me by the arguments of Pier Damiani. Something similar happens with the poem I mentioned in the first paragraph, which speaks of the irrevocability of the past. By 1951, I will believe I have fabricated a fantastic tale when in fact I will have recorded a real event; likewise, two thousand years ago, innocent Virgil believed he was heralding the birth of a man when he was prophesying the birth of God.

Poor Damián! Death took him at twenty in an obscure civil war and a forgotten battle, but he achieved what his heart desired, and it took him a long time to achieve it, and perhaps there is no greater happiness.